



million **slaves**—more than seven times the number that went to the United States—were shipped in from West Africa and sold through teeming human **markets**. Although slavery was abolished in Brazil in 1888, the direct

descendants of these early workers still dominate the present-day state of **Bahia**. In its early days, this region was known as “the province of the bay”; the name “Bahia” comes from *baia*, the Portuguese word for bay.

Candomblé

The slaves who landed in Bahia were forbidden from practicing their African faith. In order to keep hold of their beliefs, therefore, they resorted to disguise—ancient gods were hidden behind Catholic saints, and familiar customs dressed up as Christian ritual. The new religion that grew out of this strange mix is called Candomblé. Today, it defines not only the spirituality, but also the culture of Bahian life.

FIRE DANCE

African gods are called *orixás*. Passing a bowl of fire from head to head is part of the Candomblé ritual devoted to Xango, the fire *orixá*.

Dancing is another important element of the ceremony: when the movements become wild and frenzied, some believers go into a trance.



GOD OF THE SICK

Contemporary followers of Candomblé summon a grass-shrouded figure of their god Omolú, who they believe causes and cures illness. At one time, Omolú was linked with the Catholic Saint Lazarus.



SISTERS IN FAITH

Allied to Candomblé is a female society called the Sisterhood of the Good Death. Devoted to the Assumption of the Virgin, its followers (who are all over 40) express their spirituality through street processions, samba dancing, and feasting. This sister is completely clad in white, the color of Candomblé.

Worship takes place in *terreiros*, or houses of Candomblé.

CAPOEIRA

Cushioned by soft ground, young Bahian men practice *capoeira*, a blend of martial arts and dancing that warrior slaves brought with them from Africa. This move—where one person tosses the other into a midair somersault—is performed on beaches and streets all over the state.

